METRIC

A-A-20208A
September 7, 2005
SUPERSEDING
A-A-20208
June 6, 1995

COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

CHEESE, CHEDDAR, REDUCED FAT

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) has authorized the use of this Commercial Item Description (CID).

1. SCOPE. This CID covers reduced fat cheddar cheese packed in commercially acceptable containers, suitable for use by the Federal, state, local governments, and other interested parties.

2. PURCHASER NOTES.

2.1 Purchasers *shall specify* the following.

- Style(s) and shred sizes of reduced fat cheddar cheese required (Sec. 3).
- When analytical requirements are different than specified (Sec. 6.1).
- When analytical requirements need to be verified (Sec. 6.3).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's certification (Sec. 9.2) or USDA certification (Sec. 9.3).

2.2 Purchasers *may specify* the following.

- Manufacturer's quality assurance (Sec. 9.1 with 9.1.1), (Sec. 9.1 with 9.1.2), or (Sec. 9.1 with 9.1.3).
- Special labeling and packaging requirements (Sec. 10).

3. CLASSIFICATION. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall conform to the following list, which shall be specified, as required, in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

Styles and shred sizes.

Style 1 - Block

Style 2 - Shredded
Shred size a - Up to 4.75 mm (3/16 in) height and width
Shred size b - Other (as specified by purchaser)

FSC 8910

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

4. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S NOTES. Manufacturer's/distributor's products *shall meet* the requirements of the:

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 6).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's product assurance (Sec. 7).
- Regulatory requirements (Sec. 8).
- Quality assurance provisions: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 9).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 10).

5. SALIENT CHARACTERISTICS.

5.1 Processing. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall be prepared and packaged in accordance with current good manufacturing practices (21 CFR Part 110).

5.1.1 Pasteurization. All dairy ingredients shall be pasteurized at a temperature of not less than 71.7°C (161°F) for a period of not less than 15 seconds, or for a time and at a temperature equivalent thereto in phosphatase destruction.

5.1.2 Dairy ingredients. Dairy ingredients used in the manufacture of reduced fat cheddar cheese shall originate from a plant that has been approved by the Dairy Grading Branch (DGB), Dairy Programs (DP), Agricultural Marketing Service (AMS), USDA.

5.1.3 Manufacturing plants. The manufacturing plants shall be eligible for Section I listing in the most recent version of the publication Dairy Plants Surveyed and Approved for USDA Grading Service.

5.1.4 Anticaking agent. If an anticaking agent is used, the amount used shall be the minimum required to produce the desired effect, but shall not exceed 2.0 percent of the weight of the reduced fat shredded cheddar cheese.

5.2 Finished product. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall contain between 25 to 33.3 percent less fat than that of regular cheddar cheese. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall comply with all applicable Federal regulations including those contained in 21 CFR 133.113 for cheddar cheese, 21 CFR 101.62 for food nutrient content claims for fat, and 21 CFR 130.10 *Requirements for foods named by use of a nutrient content claim and a standardized term.*

5.3 Quality specifications.

5.3.1 Flavor and odor. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall have a pleasing flavor. It may be lacking in flavor development or may possess slight characteristic cheddar cheese flavor.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

The reduced fat cheddar cheese may possess very slight acid, bitter, or slight feed flavor, but shall not possess any undesirable flavors or odors.

5.3.2 Body and texture. The block reduced fat cheddar cheese body and texture shall be firm, compact, and should be slightly translucent and shiny. It may have a few mechanical openings (1 to 3 openings per plug) if not large and connecting. The block reduced fat cheddar cheese shall be free from gas holes. The body may be very slightly gummy, slightly mealy or coarse, and definite curdy. Reduced fat shredded cheddar cheese shall be free flowing and of uniform size and shape. It shall not mat, crumble, oil off, or contain excessive fines.

5.3.3 Appearance. The block reduced fat cheddar cheese shall be free of mold but may be slightly soiled, rough, or lopsided. The institutional or consumer size packages shall be free of mold and soil.

5.3.4 Color. The reduced fat cheddar cheese block shall have a fairly uniform, bright attractive appearance, and may be slightly wavy. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall be colored or uncolored, but if colored, it shall be a medium yellow-orange. The reduced fat shredded cheddar cheese shall not vary in color.

5.3.5 Shred size. For shred size a, the reduced fat shredded cheddar cheese shall have a height and width up to 4.75 mm (3/16 inch) in either dimension.

5.3.6 Fines. Reduced fat shredded cheddar cheese shall not contain more than 6.0 percent fines. For shreds whose height and/or width is 1.6 mm (1/16 inch) or less, the fines content shall be determined using a Standard Test Sieve #14 (1.4 mm). For shreds whose height and/or width is greater than 1.6 mm (1/16 inch), the fines content shall be determined using a Standard Test Sieve #8 (2.36 mm).

5.4 Age and storage requirements. The reduced fat cheddar cheese must be at least 20 days old when inspected and shall be aged at 1.7 °C to 5.5°C (35°F to 42°F) prior to inspection . This aging may take place before of after the cheese is shredded. If the cheese is refrigerated after manufacturing, the cheese must be located in a cooler and stored at temperatures between 1.7 °C to 5.5°C (35°F to 42°F) until delivered.

5.5 Shelf life. The shelf life of the reduced fat cheddar cheese shall not be less than 5 months after manufacture, when stored at 1.7 °C to 5.5°C (35°F to 42°F).

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

6. ANALYTICAL REQUIREMENTS.

6.1 Analytical requirements. Unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the reduced fat cheddar cheese shall conform to the following analytical requirements.

6.1.1 Fat content. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall contain not less than 19.2 percent total fat (as marketed) and not more than 22.9 percent total fat (as marketed).

6.1.2 Moisture content. The reduced fat cheddar cheese moisture content shall not exceed 49.0 percent.

6.1.3 Salt content. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall contain not less than 1.4 percent but not more than 2.0 percent salt.

6.1.4 pH. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall have a pH value higher than 5.30, except shredded cheese, which shall not have a pH value higher than 5.35.

6.1.5 Meltability. The reduced fat cheddar cheese shall demonstrate satisfactory meltability characteristics, and shall be at the No. 3 or greater level in accordance with the USDA, AMS, DA Instruction 918-RL, Laboratory Methods and Procedures issued on January 2, 2001.

6.2 Preparation of sample. A minimum of 100 g of reduced fat cheddar cheese must be blended to uniformity in a minimum time using a Robot Coupe food processor (AOAC method 983.18) or equivalent. This uniform sample may then be used in the analyses for fat, moisture, salt, and pH.

6.3 Analytical testing. When specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, analyses shall be in accordance with the following methods from the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International, and the latest edition of the USDA - DA Instruction 918-RL, Laboratory Methods and Procedures, or the latest edition of the Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products.

Test	Method
Fat	933.05 1/
Moisture	926.08 or 977.11 1/
Salt	935.43 or 983.14 1/
pH	Quinhydrone, Ch. 15 2/
Meltability	Section C.5 3/
Fines	Section C.5 3/

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

1/ The 17th edition of the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International
2/ The 17th edition, 2004 of the Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products
3/ The USDA, AMS, DA Instruction 918-RL, Laboratory Methods and Procedures issued on January 2, 2001

6.3.1 Test results. The test results for fat, moisture, and salt shall be reported to the nearest 0.1 percent; and pH to the nearest 0.01 value. Any result not conforming to the analytical requirements shall be cause for rejection of the lot.

7. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S PRODUCT ASSURANCE. The manufacturer/ distributor shall certify that the reduced fat cheddar cheese provided shall meet the salient characteristics of this CID, conform to their own specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices, and be the same reduced fat cheddar cheese offered for sale in the commercial market. The purchaser reserves the right to require proof of conformance.

8. REGULATORY REQUIREMENTS. The delivered reduced fat cheddar cheese shall comply with all applicable Federal and State mandatory requirements and regulations relating to the preparation, packaging, labeling, storage, distribution, and sale of the reduced fat cheddar cheese within the commercial marketplace. The delivered reduced fat cheddar cheese shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act, the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act, and regulations promulgated thereunder. When the reduced fat cheddar cheese is used for the National School Lunch Program, the cheese must comply with all applicable provisions of the Child Nutrition Programs.

9. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS. *Purchaser shall specify 9.2 or 9.3; purchaser may specify 9.1 with 9.1.1, 9.1 with 9.1.2 or 9.1 with 9.1.3.*

9.1 Manufacturer's quality assurance. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the product manufacturer shall be required to provide evidence, by certificate, that the manufacturing plant has undertaken one of the following quality assurance measures within 12 months prior to providing a bid, or no later than 10 business days from the date of awarding of the contract. Failure to provide this documentation within the proper time frame may result in the contract being terminated.

9.1.1 Plant systems audit. A plant systems audit (PSA) shall be conducted by USDA, AMS, or other third party auditing service is required within 12 months prior to the date of the awarding of the contract. *(An AMS PSA verifies the manufacturer's capability to produce products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food; and have in place an internal quality assurance program. The AMS PSA determines the*

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

manufacturer's ability to produce under this CID, if the products of interest are identified at the time of the PSA.)

9.1.2 Plant survey. A plant survey shall be conducted by USDA, AMS, or other third party auditing service is required within 12 months prior to the date of the awarding of the contract. *(An AMS plant survey audit verifies that, at the time of the survey, the manufacturer produces products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food.)*

9.1.3 Total Quality Systems Audit. A total quality systems audit (TQSA) conducted by USDA/Farm Service Agency (FSA) is required within 12 months prior to the date of the awarding of the contract. *(A FSA TQSA verifies the manufacturer's capability to produce products in a clean, sanitary environment in accordance with Title 21 Code of Federal Regulations Part 110 - Current Good Manufacturing Practice in Manufacturing, Packing, or Holding Human Food, and verifies that the manufacturer has in place an internal quality assurance program. The FSA TQSA determines the manufacturer's ability to produce under this CID, if the products of interest are identified at the time of the TQSA.)*

9.2 Manufacturer's/distributor's certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the manufacturer/distributor will certify that the reduced fat cheddar cheese distributed meets or exceeds the requirements of this CID.

9.3 USDA certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order that product quality or acceptability or both be determined, USDA, AMS, DGB, DP shall be the certifying agency. DGB shall certify the quality and acceptability of the reduced fat cheddar cheese in accordance with agency procedures which include selecting random samples of the reduced fat cheddar cheese, evaluating the samples for conformance with the salient characteristic of this CID and other contractual requirements, and documenting the findings on official score sheets and/or certificates. In addition, when required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, DGB inspectors will examine the reduced fat cheddar cheese for conformance to the United States Standards of Condition of Food Containers in effect on the date of the solicitation.

10. PACKAGING. Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and case marking shall be in accordance with good commercial packaging unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

11. USDA INSPECTION NOTES. When Section 9.3 is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, USDA certification shall include evaluation of the quality and

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 2026-10-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.

condition of samples of the reduced fat cheddar cheese and compliance with requirements in the following areas.

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Analytical requirements *when specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order* (Sec. 6.1). When USDA testing of reduced fat cheddar cheese is specified, DGB inspection personnel shall select samples and conduct the tests.
- Packaging requirements (Sec. 10 or as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order).

12. REFERENCE NOTES.

12.1 USDA Certification Contacts.

12.1.1 USDA certification contact. For USDA certification, contact the **Branch Chief, DGB, DP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0230, 1400 Independence Ave., SW, Washington, DC 20250-0230, telephone (202) 720-7471 or on the Internet at: www.ams.usda.gov/dairy/grade.htm.**

12.1.2 Total Quality Systems Audit contact. Inquiries about services and fees should be directed to: **Warehouse Licensing and Examination Division, Stop 9148, Kansas City Commodity Office, 6501 Beacon Drive, Kansas City, Missouri 64133-6476, telephone (816) 926-6417 or Fax (816) 926-1774, Website: http://www.fsa.usda.gov/daco/pdd/tqsa.htm.**

12.1.3 CN meal pattern requirements contact. For CN crediting information, contact the **Head, Technical Assistance Section, Child Nutrition Division, Food and Nutrition Service, 3101 Park Center Drive, Alexandria, VA 22302, telephone (703) 305-2609 or on the Internet at: http.//www.fns.usda.gov/fns.**

12.2 Sources of documents.

12.2.1 Sources of information for nongovernmental documents is as follows:

Copies of the Official Methods of Analysis of the AOAC International may be obtained from: **AOAC International, 481 North Fredrick Avenue, Suite 500, Gaithersburg, MD 20877-2417, telephone (301) 924-7077. Internet address: http://www.aoac.org.**

Copies of the Standard Methods for the Examination of Dairy Products may be obtained from: **American Public Health Association, Publications Sale, P.O. Box 753, Waldorf, MD 20604-0753, telephone (301) 893-1894 or on the Internet address at: https://secure.matrixgroup.net/apha/media/orderform.cfm.**

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the currentversion before use.

12.2.2 Sources of information for governmental documents are as follows:

Applicable provisions of the: the Child Nutrition Programs are contained in 7 CFR Parts 210, 220, 225, 226, and Appendices A and C; the Fair Packaging and Labeling Act are contained in 16 CFR Parts 500 to 503; and the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act is contained in 21 CFR Parts 1 to 199. These documents may be purchased from. **Superintendent of Documents, New Orders, P.O. Box 371954, Pittsburgh, PA 15250-7954. Credit card (MasterCard or Visa) purchases may be made by calling the Superintendent of Documents on (202) 512-1803 or on the Internet at: http://www.gpoaccess.gov/nara/index.html .**

Copies of the General Specifications for Dairy Plants Approved for USDA Inspection and Grading Service, Dairy Plants Surveyed and Approved for USDA Grading Service, and DA INSTRUCTION 918-RL, Resident Grading Quality Control Service Programs and Laboratory Analysis are available from: **Dairy Grading Branch, Dairy Programs, AMS, USDA, STOP 0230, 1400 Independence Ave., SW, Washington, DC 20250-0230, telephone (202) 720-7471 or on the Internet at: www.ams.usda.gov/dairy/grade.htm.**

Copies of this CID, the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers, and beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc. and any data which may improve this CID are available from and/or provided to. **Head, Food Quality Assurance Staff, Fruit and Vegetable Programs, AMS, USDA, STOP 0243, 1400 Independence Avenue, SW, Washington, DC 20250-0243, telephone (202) 720-9939, Fax (202) 690-0102, via E-mail. FQAStaff@usda.gov or on the Internet at: http.//www.ams.usda.gov/fv/fvqual.htm.**

CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:

DOJ - BOP
HHS - NIH, FDA
USDA - FV, FSA, DA
VA - OSS

PREPARING ACTIVITY:

USDA - FV

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) prohibits discrimination in all its programs and activities on the basis of race, color, national origin, age, disability, and where applicable, sex, marital status, familial status, parental status, religion, sexual orientation, genetic information, political beliefs, reprisal, or because all or a part of an individual's income is derived from any public assistance program. (Not all prohibited bases apply to all programs.) Persons with disabilities who require alternative means for communication of program information (Braille, large print, audiotape, etc.) should contact USDA's TARGET Center at (202) 720-2600 (voice and TDD). To file a complaint of discrimination write to USDA, Director, Office of Civil Rights, 1400 Independence Avenue, S.W., Washington, D.C. 20250-9410 or call (800) 795-3272 (voice) or (202) 720-6382 (TDD). USDA is an equal opportunity provider and employer.

Source: https://assist.dla.mil -- Downloaded: 202610-26T08:34Z
Check the source to verify that this is the current version before use.